

Cover to Cover

DIVIDED BY LOT, DESIGNED BY GOD

Joshua

Teaching Notes

Romans 15:4

Amplified Bible, Classic Edition

4 For whatever was thus written in former days was written for our instruction, that by [our steadfast and patient] endurance and the encouragement [drawn] from the Scriptures we might hold fast to *and* cherish hope.

I want to first address a question from last week about the violence that we see taking place in possessing the land in the book of Joshua.

When we read parts of the Old Testament—especially in Book of Joshua—it can feel shocking.

Entire cities are destroyed.

That raises a real question: *How could a good God allow or command that?*

Move from “war story” to “moral intervention”

When we read these stories....most people picture:

Israel invading innocent people.

But what is really going on is:

God intervening in a culture that had become deeply destructive.

- **This is NOT**
- **Not random war**
- **But judgment after long-term moral collapse**

You have to go alllll the way back to Genesis 15:16...then in the fourth generation your descendants shall return to Canaan, the land of promise, for the wickedness and guild of the Amorites is not yet complete (finished).

NET commentary states: *The sin of the Amorites has not yet reached its limit.* The justice of God is apparent. He will wait until the Amorites are fully deserving of judgment before he annihilates them and gives the land to Israel.

Historical reality: What were the Amorites doing?

The cultures in Canaan (including the Amorites) were known for:

- **Idolatry**
- **Child sacrifice**
- **Sexual perversion**

- Violence and injustice
(You can see this described later in Leviticus 18 and Deuteronomy 12.)

God wasn't reacting to minor issues—this was **deep, systemic evil**.

5. The shocking truth: God gave them 400+ years

In Genesis 15, God tells Abraham:

- His descendants will be in Egypt for about **400 years**
- **THEN** they will return

That means:

The Amorites had **centuries** to change.

Let that sink in.

God waited generations before executing judgment.

Make the moral issues very concrete

According to the biblical picture of Canaanite culture, this included:

Child sacrifice

- Parents would **burn their own children alive** as offerings to gods like Molech

- This wasn't rare or hidden—it was **institutionalized worship**

“Imagine a culture where the worst thing you can think of—killing children—is not only accepted, but *celebrated as religion*.”

Sexual exploitation and distortion

- Ritual prostitution (including temple prostitution)
- Practices that blurred boundaries of family, power, and sexuality
- Sexual acts tied directly to worship and control

This wasn't just immorality—it was:

spiritualized exploitation

Violence and lack of justice

- Power-driven societies where the strong dominated the weak
- No real protection for the vulnerable
- Violence embedded into daily life

Idolatry tied to all of it

This is key: in the Bible, idolatry isn't just "wrong belief."

It's:

a system that produces destructive behavior

So worship and morality were fused:

- Worship false gods → adopt destructive practices
- Those practices → destroy human life and dignity

"If you walked into a society today where children were routinely sacrificed, abuse was normalized, and violence controlled everything... you wouldn't just ask for reform—you would say, *'This has to stop.'*"

That's the category the Bible is placing this in.

Emphasize God's patience before judgment

This is often missed but critical.

In Book of Genesis 15:16, God tells Abraham:

judgment will wait **hundreds of years (400 to be exact)**

So this wasn't sudden.

say:

- God gave time (centuries)

- Opportunity for change existed
- Judgment came **after prolonged corruption**

Clarify Israel's role (this prevents misunderstanding)

Make this very clear:

Israel wasn't told, 'Go take whatever land you want. They were told, 'I am bringing judgment—and you are part of that moment.'”

Also remind them:

- Israel itself is later judged the same way when it becomes corrupt
- So this is not favoritism—it's **consistent justice**

Bring balance: this is not a model for today

This was a specific moment in history—not a general command for people to carry out violence in God's name.

Later, especially in the teachings of Jesus:

- **The focus shifts to transformation, mercy, and redemption**
- **The battle becomes spiritual, not physical**

A **big-picture** takeaway

The violence in the Old Testament isn't there to celebrate war—it's there to show how seriously God takes evil.

It confronts us with two realities:

1. Evil can become so destructive that it demands intervention
2. God is patient—but He is not indifferent”

LAND DISTRIBUTION INTRODUCTION (5–7 minutes)

If you just skim through the later chapters of the *Book of Joshua*, it can feel like a long list of boundaries, cities, and measurements.

At first glance, it reads like real estate records.

But if you slow down, you'll discover something powerful: this is not just land distribution—it is **God fulfilling promises, honoring prophecy, and revealing identity.**

What looks like geography is actually theology.

What looks like division is actually design.

Every tribe's placement tells a story—about their past, their calling, and even their future.

This land was promised generations earlier, spoken over by Jacob, reaffirmed through Moses, and now fulfilled under Joshua.

This is the moment where **promise becomes possession**.

And here's why this matters: the same God who assigned their inheritance is still assigning purpose, placement, and calling today.

THE SYSTEM: WHY THIS WAS NOT RANDOM (5 minutes)

The land was divided by casting lots—but make no mistake, this wasn't chance. In biblical thinking, the lot was a way of letting God decide.

According to GINZBERG and others, ancient Rabbis believed the division of land west of the Jordan was divided into 10 provinces and assigned a number for each province.

Numbers one to 10 were written on 10 pieces of pottery or parchment and put into a container.

Then the names of the 10 tribes receiving land on the west side of the Jordan were written on 10 pieces of pottery or parchment and put into a second container.

Joshua drew from one container and Eleazar and the others drew from the other.

The tribe drawn received the land of the province drawn!

God commanded it be done by a lot in numbers 26:55–56; 33:54. This way left the choices up to God. God became the real estate agent.

Casting lots for the land division removed... Favoritism... Human bias... Political manipulation.

God himself became the real estate agent

Human hands cast it, but divine will directed it. God was intentionally placing each tribe exactly where they needed to be.

This means their inheritance was not based on:

- Strength
- Popularity
- Performance

It was based on **promise and identity**.

And even more—some of the land hadn't been fully conquered yet when it was assigned. God gave them territory they still had to step into. That tells us something: **God will give you**

something before you feel ready to fully walk in it.

KINGDOM ADVANCEMENT:

The purpose of Israel's conquest of Canaan was to move toward the goal when Abraham's descendants would succeed in spreading the blessings of God throughout the Earth. Genesis 12:1–3.

The promised land was the place where God determined to establish Israel as a kingdom that would one day become a worldwide empire. See Psalm 72. (This Psalm is a Royal Psalm...depicts the King's universal rule).

When this kingdom turned from the Lord, he exiled them from their homeland for centuries... The prophets boldly proclaimed that after the exile, David's righteous royal Son would take his throne and spread the kingdom of Israel to the ends of the Earth. Isaiah 9:6–7; Jeremiah 23:5.

Joshua contributes to the spread of God's reign as the first of six books in the Old Testament that focus on segments of Israel's history with heavy reliance on the covenant perspective of the first five books of the Bible, especially in Deuteronomy.

So the study of Joshua and the next five books along with it, we will be focusing on the spread of God's kingdom reign.

Joshua

Judges

First and second, Samuel

First and second Kings

THE TRIBES AND THEIR ALLOTMENTS

REUBEN (2–3 minutes)

Reuben, the firstborn of Jacob, received land east of the Jordan River. His territory stretched from the Arnon Gorge up toward the Dead Sea region. It was fertile land, suitable for livestock, which aligned with why the tribe chose to settle there even before crossing into the Promised Land. This area had previously belonged to defeated Amorite kings, and Moses granted it to them at their request.

But there's tension in Reuben's story. Though he was the firstborn, he did not receive prominence. Jacob had prophesied instability over him because of his past failure, and that plays out here.

(Reuben slept with his father's concubine...Bilhah...Genesis 35:22:

- The mother of two of Reuben's brothers (Dan and Naphtali)

This act was more than sexual sin—it was a **direct violation of his father's authority and household.**

In ancient culture this was seen as: **a Power Move**

Sleeping with a father's concubine was often seen as an attempt to:

- Assert dominance
- Claim leadership
- Undermine the father's authority

((We see a similar act later when Absalom sleeps with David's concubines (2 Samuel 16), symbolizing rebellion and a takeover.))

So Reuben's action may have been an attempt—whether intentional or impulsive—to **position himself as the next leader of the family**.

He ALREADY was in this position...but he just wanted it sooner than it was going to happen.

Genesis 49, Jacob addresses Reuben:

“Reuben, you are my firstborn...
unstable as water, you shall not excel,
because you went up to your father's bed...”

This is where the phrase comes from.

WHAT REUBEN LOST

Because of this one failure, Reuben forfeited key rights of the firstborn:

- 1.

Leadership → Given to Judah

(Jesus ultimately comes through Judah)

2.

Double Portion → Given to Joseph

(Ephraim & Manasseh)

3.

Priesthood → Given to Levi

Reuben lost **influence, inheritance weight, and legacy positioning**

So...watch this....just like he was close to the promise of the leader of the family...he never was fully in it because of what he did to dishonor his father.

And now....in the land...

Reuben settled outside the central land of promise. Spiritually, this reflects a life that is **close to promise—but not fully in it**. He had land, but not the same level of influence or centrality as others.

GAD (2–3 minutes)

Gad also settled east of the Jordan, just north of Reuben. Their land was rugged but rich, stretching into Gilead.

It was a region known for its balm and healing resources.

THE BALM OF GILEAD”?

The phrase comes from passages like:

- Jeremiah 8:22 — “*Is there no balm in Gilead?*”
- Genesis 37:25 — traders carrying balm from Gilead

The “balm” refers to a **resin or medicinal ointment** extracted from trees in the region.

It was:

- Highly valuable
- Used for **healing wounds and soothing pain**
- Exported and traded across the region

So Gilead wasn’t just farmland—it was known as a place of **healing resources**.

3. WHY THIS IS POWERFUL (EMOTIONAL INSIGHT)

Gad lived in a place that:

- Produced **healing**
- But also experienced **conflict and invasion**

That tension is powerful:

- A land known for healing
- Occupied by people constantly in battle

It reflects a deep truth:

You can carry something that heals others while still fighting your own battles.

4. WHEN WAS GILEAD CONQUERED?

Gilead was conquered **before Israel crossed into the Promised Land (west of the Jordan)**.

Timeline:

During the wilderness journey under **Moses**:

1. Israel defeated:

- King Sihon (Amorites)
- **Og**

□ Numbers 21:24–35

□ Deuteronomy 3

2. These victories gave Israel control of:

- Gilead
- Bashan

3. Then in **Numbers 32**, the tribe of Gad (along with Reuben and part of Manasseh) requested that land

□ So:

Gilead was conquered BEFORE Joshua's campaigns in Canaan

Gad's territory placed them in a position of both opportunity and vulnerability, as they were exposed to outside enemies more than tribes inside Canaan.

Jacob had prophesied that Gad would be attacked but would ultimately triumph.

That prophetic word aligns with their geographic reality—they lived on the frontier.

Gad represents believers who are positioned on the edge, often in spiritual battles, yet called to overcome. Their placement wasn't punishment—it was purpose.

MORE DETAILS:

Gad's placement east of the Jordan put them in a **beautiful but exposed position**. Their land in Gilead was fertile, ideal for livestock, and rich in resources—but it came with a cost. Unlike

the tribes settled deeper in Canaan, Gad lived on the **frontier**, meaning they were the first line of contact when enemies approached from the east. This wasn't accidental; it directly echoed Jacob's prophetic word in Genesis 49:19: "*Gad, a troop shall tramp upon him, but he shall triumph at last.*" In other words, their identity was tied to conflict—but also to resilience. They weren't placed there to fail, but to **develop strength through pressure**.

Historically, Gad did face repeated attacks. Because of their location, they were vulnerable to surrounding nations like the Ammonites and later invading forces such as the Assyrians. In 1 Chronicles 5, we see that the tribes east of the Jordan—including Gad—were eventually overtaken and taken into exile earlier than the rest of Israel. Their exposure made them more susceptible to outside influence and spiritual drift. Yet, in the midst of that, Scripture also highlights their strength: the men of Gad are described as **mighty warriors, fierce like lions, swift like gazelles** (1 Chronicles 12:8). So while they were attacked, they were also uniquely equipped. Their battles didn't just reveal vulnerability—they revealed strength.

There's something deeply practical and emotional here. Gad represents people who live "on the edge"—those who feel like they're always in a fight, always navigating pressure, always on the front lines of life or spiritual battles. It can feel unfair, like others are safe while you're constantly contending. But Gad's story reminds us: **your placement is not punishment—it's**

assignment.

The very place that exposes you is also the place that shapes you.

And even though they were prophesied to be attacked, that wasn't the end of the sentence—they would triumph. That means the struggle you're in may not be a sign you're out of place, but evidence that you're exactly where strength is being formed.

HALF-TRIBE OF MANASSEH (EAST) (2–3 minutes)

The half-tribe of Manasseh received land north of Gad, extending into Bashan. This region was known for its strength, forests, and fortified cities.

It had previously been ruled by King Og, one of the last of the giants. So this wasn't just land—it was territory that had a history of intimidation and opposition.

In numbers 32 it talks about Ruben and GAD approaching Moses and requesting to stay on the east side of Jordan... Manasseh does not originally request to stay east... They are granted an inheritance based on conquest and clan presence already there.

In numbers 32:33... 39–42. It states that MACHIR son of Manasseh went to Gilead and took it and dispossessed the Emirates who were in it.

So Moses gave Gilead to MACHIR. They had already entirely taken land there in Gilead... So Moses formally grants it to them.

It was a confirmed inheritance rather than a separate request.

Got it—here's the corrected version with only English:

The half-tribe of Manasseh ended up divided because of a decision made **before Israel ever crossed the Jordan River**. In Numbers 32, the tribes of Reuben and Gad asked to settle east of the Jordan because the land was ideal for livestock. The tribe of Manasseh—being large and influential—also joined them, but only partially. So half of Manasseh stayed east (in places like Bashan and Gilead), while the other half crossed over into Canaan and received land on the west side. This split wasn't random—it reflected both **practical needs (land capacity)** and a willingness among part of the tribe to settle early. But it also created a lasting division within one family line—same tribe, different experiences, different levels of exposure.

The eastern half of Manasseh inherited strong, strategic territory—land once ruled by powerful kings like Og of Bashan, a region known for fortified cities and even associations with giants. It was a place of former intimidation that now became their responsibility. Like Gad, they lived on the frontier, exposed to outside nations. Over time, that exposure took a toll. In 1 Chronicles 5, we're told that the eastern tribes—including this

half of Manasseh—were among the first to fall into idolatry and were eventually taken into exile by the Assyrians. Their distance from the central place of worship and constant pressure from surrounding cultures made them more vulnerable to drift. They had strong land—but maintaining spiritual strength in that environment required constant vigilance.

There’s a powerful life lesson here. Manasseh’s name means “to forget,” and in a healthy sense, it speaks of leaving past pain behind. But their story shows the danger of forgetting the wrong things—forgetting identity, covenant, and connection. When part of your life settles “on the edge,” disconnected from the center, it becomes easier to slowly compromise without realizing it. Practically, this speaks to staying rooted—spiritually, relationally, and in community. Emotionally, it reminds us that even strong people in strong places can drift if they lose connection to what grounds them. The split tribe of Manasseh shows us that **where you position yourself—and what you stay connected to—matters more than you think.**

JUDAH (4–5 minutes)

Tribe of Judah – Land, Placement, and Purpose

Territory & Strategic Placement

- Judah received the **largest and most strategically significant territory** in southern Canaan (Joshua 15)
- Their land included:
 - The wilderness (south)

- The hill country
- The western lowlands
- This gave them:
 - **Natural defense** (mountains and elevation)
 - **Access to key travel and trade routes**
- Their placement was intentional and aligned with **Genesis 49:10**:
 - “The scepter shall not depart from Judah”
- Judah was:
 - Marked for **leadership before the land was assigned**
 - Positioned in a place that could **sustain growth and support a future kingdom**
- Key insight:
 - God doesn’t just call people to lead—He **positions them where leadership can develop**

Jerusalem and Its Connection to Judah

- Jerusalem sat on the **border between Judah and Benjamin** (Joshua 15:8; 18:28)
- Originally called **Jebus**, it was:
 - Not fully conquered during Joshua’s time
 - Controlled by the Jebusites during the period of the Judges
- It remained unconquered until:
 - **David captured it** (2 Samuel 5)
- After David’s victory:
 - Jerusalem became the **political and spiritual capital of Israel**
- Key insight:

- The most important city was already within Judah's territory
- But it required the **right leader and timing** to fully possess it
- Teaching point:
 - Some promises are **in your territory but require the right season and person to fulfill them**

Judah as the Tribe of David and Kingship

- Judah's leadership role was rooted in:
 - **Jacob's prophecy (Genesis 49)** pointing to kingship
- Over time, Judah:
 - Grew in **strength and influence** among the tribes
- Israel's first king:
 - **Saul (from Benjamin)**—a temporary shift in leadership
- God then established:
 - **David (from Judah)** as king
 - A **lasting covenant** with his lineage (2 Samuel 7)
- From that point forward:
 - Kingship remained tied to Judah
 - This line ultimately led to **Jesus, the Messiah**

Key Spiritual & Generational Insights

- God plants **seeds of destiny long before they are visible**
- Judah carried a promise **generations before fulfillment**
- Leadership is often:
 - **Prophesied early**

- **Developed over time**
- **Revealed in the right season**
- Faithfulness over time allows:
 - Destiny to **impact future generations**

Strong Teaching Lines

- “Judah was positioned for leadership before leadership ever appeared.”
- “Some promises sit in your territory waiting for the right season.”
- “God plants destiny early, but reveals it over time.”

“The scepter will not depart, until Shiloh comes”....

Shiloh was both a geographical location and a physical location. It's the site where the Tabernacle was established in these early years in the Promised Land.

Shiloh becomes the spiritual headquarters of Israel.

The tabernacles location.

The place where major decision, worship and feasts were centered.

This remained the primary worship site through Joshua's and Judges.

It was also a prophetic title of Jesus.

Refers to Him as a future ruler from the tribe of Judah. Gen 49:10

It's a Messianic Prophecy!

Jacob/Israel's prophecy about Judah's rulership waited 1850 years to reach Jesus.

CALEB (SPECIAL PORTION – HEBRON) (3–4 minutes)

Caleb, though part of Judah, stands out. At 85 years old, he asked for Hebron—a mountain filled with giants. This was not easy land. It was contested, intimidating, and dangerous.

Here's a deeper, research-based expansion on **Caleb and Hebron**, written in a way you can teach it with clarity, weight, and meaning.

CALEB & HEBRON — MORE THAN LAND, IT WAS LEGACY

1. What Caleb Asked For (Joshua 14)

Caleb comes to Joshua at 85 years old and says:

“Give me this mountain...” (Joshua 14:12)

Specifically, he is asking for **Hebron**, a place still occupied by the **Anakim (giants)** at the time.

This is striking:

- He is not asking for easy land

- He is asking for **unfinished business**
- He is asking for the very place that once caused fear in Israel

According to commentary traditions (including Enduring Word), Caleb is essentially saying:

“The place that intimidated others is the place I want to possess.”

2. What Makes Hebron So Significant?

Hebron is one of the most spiritually loaded locations in all of Scripture.

A. Connection to the Patriarchs

Hebron is where:

- Abraham lived (Genesis 13:18)
- Abraham built an altar to the Lord
- Abraham purchased the cave of Machpelah (Genesis 23)

It became the burial place of:

- Abraham and Sarah
- Isaac and Rebekah
- Jacob and Leah

□ This means Hebron is not just land—it is **covenant ground**

B. One of the Oldest Cities in the Region

- Joshua 14:15 notes Hebron was formerly called **Kiriath-Arba**
- It was associated with **Arba, a great man among the Anakim (giants)**

So Hebron carried:

- Deep covenant history
- But also deep **intimidation and opposition**

C. Future Significance

Hebron later becomes:

- The place where **David is first crowned king** (2 Samuel 2:1–4)

□ This means Caleb wasn't just taking land—he was stepping into a place that would later be tied to **kingship and destiny**

3. WHY DID CALEB WANT HEBRON?

A. It Was the Land of Promise He Personally Saw

Caleb was one of the 12 spies sent into Canaan (Numbers 13).

“Caleb specifically scouted Hebron”

It **strongly implies it**:

□ **Numbers 13:22**

“They went up into the South and came to Hebron...”

This tells us:

- The spies (including Caleb) physically walked through Hebron
- They saw:
 - The land
 - The giants (Anakim)

B. Hebron Was Where Fear Was Introduced

Hebron is where:

- The giants lived
- The discouraging report began to take shape

Ten spies saw:

- **Obstacles**

Caleb saw:

- **Opportunity**

C. Caleb Was Revisiting a Defining Moment

Forty-five years later, Caleb is essentially saying:

□ “Take me back to the place where others lost faith—because I never did.”

This is deeply emotional:

- He carried that moment for decades
- He never let go of what he saw God could do

4. WHAT COMMENTARY SOURCES HIGHLIGHT

Enduring Word Insight

Caleb’s request shows:

- Bold, specific faith
- A refusal to settle for less
- A desire to claim what others avoided

TorahClass Insight (theme-based)

Hebron represents:

- A place where **promise and opposition meet**
- A test of whether you will believe what God said over what you see

Dr. Richard Booker (teaching themes)

Hebron is often highlighted as:

- A place of **covenant connection**
- A place tied to **inheritance and identity**

5. WHAT HAPPENED WHEN CALEB TOOK HEBRON

□ Joshua 15:13–14

- Caleb drives out:
 - The sons of Anak (giants)
- He fully possesses the land

□ What once caused fear is now fully removed

6. PRACTICAL + EMOTIONAL INSIGHT

A. He Didn't Forget What God Showed Him

Caleb held onto a promise for **45 years**

□ Some things God shows you are not immediate—they are **long-term assignments**

B. He Chose Purpose Over Comfort

At 85:

- He didn't ask for rest
- He asked for a fight

□ That challenges the idea that:

- Age limits calling
- Or that comfort equals blessing

C. He Returned to the Place of Testing

Hebron represents:

- The place where fear once spoke loudest

And Caleb says:

□ “That’s exactly where I want to go back.”

7. POWERFUL TEACHING LINES

- “Caleb didn’t run from what scared others—he ran toward it.”
- “He asked for the mountain because he remembered the promise.”
- “The place that tested your faith may be the place of your inheritance.”

8. FINAL SUMMARY

- Hebron was:
 - Covenant land
 - Giant territory
 - A place of past testing
 - A place of future kingship
- Caleb wanted it because:
 - He had seen it before
 - He believed God when others didn’t
 - He refused to let fear rewrite his future

If you want, I can:

- Turn Caleb into a full **standalone sermon**
- Or connect Hebron symbolically to **spiritual strongholds and breakthrough teaching**

EPHRAIM (3 minutes)

Joseph was one of Jacob's (Israel's) sons, but his inheritance took a unique form because of what Jacob did in **Genesis 48**. Instead of giving Joseph one tribal portion like his brothers, Jacob **adopted Joseph's two sons—Ephraim and Manasseh—as his own** and gave them equal standing with the other tribes. In essence, Joseph received a **double portion**, which was the right of the firstborn—even though he wasn't the firstborn. So instead of a single tribe called "Joseph," his inheritance was multiplied into two tribes.

This fulfilled both honor and restoration: Joseph, who had been rejected and sold by his brothers, was now given increased legacy and influence in Israel.

Emotionally, this tells a powerful story about how God redeems what was broken. Joseph's life was marked by betrayal, delay, and hardship—but his ending was marked by **overflow and generational impact**.

His name doesn't disappear—it expands. His legacy doesn't shrink into one tribe—it stretches into two. God didn't just

restore Joseph; He **multiplied his influence beyond what was expected.**

It's a reminder that what looks like loss in one season can become greater fruit in another. Sometimes God doesn't just give back what was taken—He builds something through you that blesses generations beyond you.

EPHRAIM — WHEN GOD REVERSES EXPECTATIONS

1. THE MOMENT THAT CHANGED EVERYTHING (GENESIS 48)

Before the land was ever divided, something prophetic happened between **Jacob** and Joseph's two sons, **Ephraim** and **Manasseh**.

By tradition:

- The **firstborn (Manasseh)** should receive the greater blessing
- The **right hand** of the father represented the greater inheritance

But when Jacob goes to bless them, he does something shocking:

□ He **crosses his arms**

- Right hand → Ephraim (younger)
- Left hand → Manasseh (older)

Joseph tries to correct him, but Jacob refuses and says:

“I know, my son... he also shall become great, but his younger brother shall be greater.”

2. WHAT THAT MEANS (PRACTICALLY)

This moment establishes a principle:

- God is not bound by natural order
- Birth order does not determine destiny
- God can **override expectation with intention**

Ephraim is given:

- **Greater influence**
- **Greater expansion**
- A prophetic future of becoming a “multitude of nations”

Before land was ever assigned, **Ephraim’s future was already elevated**

3. HOW THAT AFFECTED THE LAND ALLOTMENT (JOSHUA 16–17)

When the land is divided, Ephraim receives territory in the **central hill country of Canaan**.

This is significant because:

- It is **fertile and well-watered land**
- It sits in a **central position geographically**
- It becomes a place of **connection, movement, and influence**

Even more important:

□ The central place of worship, **Shiloh**, is located within Ephraim's territory.

That means:

- The presence of God is literally placed in their region
- National gatherings happen in their land
- Spiritual life flows through their territory

4. WHY THIS MATTERS

Ephraim didn't just get land—he got:

- **Position**
- **Influence**
- **Access to the presence of God**

This directly reflects Jacob's crossed-hands blessing.

The one who was unexpectedly elevated is now **centrally positioned**

5. WHAT WAS SIGNIFICANT ABOUT EPHRAIM'S LAND

A. It Was Central

Everything flowed through Ephraim:

- Travel routes
- National gatherings
- Worship

If something important was happening, it often happened near them

B. It Became a Leading Tribe

Later in Israel's history:

- Ephraim becomes so dominant that the **northern kingdom is sometimes called "Ephraim"**

That's influence.

C. It Carried Spiritual Responsibility

Having Shiloh meant:

- They were close to God’s presence
- But also accountable for how they stewarded it

C. Proximity to God Is Both a Gift and a Responsibility

They lived near the center of worship.

That means:

- Easy access to God
- But also greater accountability

And later in history, Ephraim struggles with pride and idolatry.

Being close to God’s presence doesn’t automatically mean you stay aligned—you still have to choose it

CLOSING LINE

“Before Ephraim ever stepped into the land, God had already stepped into his future.”

1. FROM FAVOR TO PRIDE

Ephraim started to **see their position as entitlement instead of responsibility.**

In Judges 8 and 12, Ephraim complains and even creates conflict with other leaders because they felt overlooked. Instead of serving from their position, they began **defending their status.**

The shift was subtle:

- From “God chose us”
- To “We deserve this”

And that’s the danger of blessing:
when identity turns into ego, stewardship begins to slip.

2. FROM PROXIMITY TO GOD → COMPLACENCY

Ephraim had something no other tribe had:

- The center of worship in their territory
- Regular access to the presence of God

But instead of that producing humility, it eventually produced **familiarity without reverence.**

In passages like Hosea, Ephraim becomes symbolic of spiritual decline:

“Ephraim is joined to idols...” (Hosea 4:17)

□ That's shocking:

The tribe closest to worship became **the most associated with idolatry**.

3. FROM INFLUENCE TO IDOLATRY

Eventually, Ephraim becomes the **leading tribe of the northern kingdom of Israel** after the nation divides.

But instead of leading people toward God, they lead them away.

- They establish false worship centers
- They turn to idols
- They drift from covenant identity

So much so that:

□ The prophets begin using “Ephraim” as a name for the entire rebellious kingdom

4. THE CORE ISSUE: MISMANAGED BLESSING

Ephraim's failure was not lack of opportunity—it was **lack of stewardship**.

They had:

- Position
- Access
- Influence

- Prophetic favor

But they failed to:

- Stay humble
- Stay aligned
- Stay faithful

5. PRACTICAL + EMOTIONAL INSIGHT

A. Blessing Requires Maintenance

What God gives you:

- Must be guarded
- Must be nurtured
- Must be kept aligned

☐ You don't just receive blessing—you **manage it**

B. Proximity Is Not the Same as Intimacy

Ephraim lived near God's presence—but that didn't mean they stayed connected to Him.

☐ You can be:

- Around spiritual things
- In spiritual environments

And still drift if your heart disconnects

C. Influence Amplifies Direction

When Ephraim drifted, they didn't drift alone—they **led others with them**

□ The greater the influence, the greater the responsibility

6. PREACHING LINES

- “Ephraim didn't fall because they lacked blessing—they fell because they mismanaged it.”
- “What God gives you can elevate you—or expose you, depending on how you steward it.”
- “Being close to the presence is not the same as valuing the presence.”
- “The same tribe that carried influence can become a warning if they stop honoring what gave them that influence.”

7. POWERFUL SUMMARY

Ephraim shows us:

- God may choose you unexpectedly
- God may position you centrally
- God may trust you with influence

But if you don't steward it well:

□ The very blessing that lifted you can become the thing that leads you off course

CLOSING THOUGHT

“Ephraim was proof that being chosen is not the finish line—it's the starting point of responsibility.”

MANASSEH (WEST) (3 minutes)

The other half of Manasseh received land west of the Jordan, overlapping with powerful regions

The western half of **Manasseh** lived in a place full of potential, yet marked by unfinished obedience.

They were surrounded by opportunity—fertile land, strategic positioning, and proximity to other strong tribes—but they made a quiet decision that shaped their future: **they tolerated what God told them to remove.**

Joshua 17 makes it clear—they could not drive out the inhabitants, even though they had the strength to do so.

Joshua 17:12–13, instead they (Manasseh) kept them around and used them as forced labor (Canaanite's)

Over time, **what they once allowed became something they had to live with.**

Those remaining influences didn't stay neutral; they slowly shaped culture, values, and priorities.

It wasn't a sudden collapse—it was a gradual drift.

And that's what makes their story so real: sometimes loss doesn't come through a dramatic fall, but through small compromises that feel manageable in the moment.

Emotionally, there's something sobering here. The western Manasseh had enough strength to conquer, but not enough resolve to finish.

You can almost feel the tension—they weren't weak, they weren't defeated, but they weren't fully free either. They lived in land that was promised, but not completely purified.

That creates a picture many people can relate to: living in something God gave you, but still wrestling with things that were supposed to be removed.

Their story reminds us that partial obedience can look like progress on the outside, but still leave internal battles unresolved.

And over time, what you don't confront, you eventually coexist with—and what you coexist with can begin to define you if you're not careful.

Ephraim's story is one of the clearest biblical examples of **how blessing must be stewarded well—or it can turn into downfall**. They were uniquely favored: elevated by **Jacob** over Manasseh, given central land in Joshua, and entrusted with the Tabernacle at **Shiloh**. But over time, that privilege became something they mismanaged.

EPHRAIM vs. MANASSEH — “THE TEST OF BLESSING”

1. ORIGIN & BLESSING (GENESIS 48)

Ephraim

- Younger son
- Unexpectedly elevated
- Received the **greater blessing** when Jacob crossed his hands
- Prophesied to become a **multitude of nations**
- Marked early for **influence and prominence**

Manasseh

- Firstborn son
- Should have received the primary blessing
- Still blessed—but **secondary to Ephraim**
- Promised to become great, but not greater
- Marked for **strength, but not central prominence**

Teaching Contrast

- Ephraim = **Chosen unexpectedly**
- Manasseh = **Passed over but still blessed**

□ God's plan doesn't always follow human order

2. LAND & POSITION (JOSHUA 16–17)

Ephraim

- Received **central territory in Canaan**
- Included the location of the Tabernacle at **Shiloh**
- Positioned at the **heart of national life**
- High visibility, high influence

Manasseh

- Received a **divided inheritance**:
 - Half east of the Jordan (frontier land)
 - Half west (less centralized than Ephraim)
- Spread out geographically
- Less centralized influence

Teaching Contrast

- Ephraim = **Central position**
- Manasseh = **Distributed responsibility**

□ One was placed at the center, the other stretched across regions

3. RESPONSE TO BLESSING

Ephraim

- Developed **pride and entitlement** over time
- Complained when not recognized (Judges 8, 12)
- Relied on position instead of humility
- Drifted spiritually despite proximity to God

Manasseh

- Showed **inconsistency and compromise**
- Did not fully drive out enemies (Joshua 17)
- Eastern half drifted due to distance from worship center
- Struggled with divided focus

Teaching Contrast

- Ephraim = **Pride from prominence**
- Manasseh = **Compromise from division**

□ One misused influence, the other lacked focus

4. LONG-TERM OUTCOME

Ephraim

- Became dominant tribe in northern kingdom
- Eventually associated with **idolatry and rebellion**
- Name “Ephraim” used by prophets to represent **spiritual decline**

Manasseh

- Less dominant, more fragmented
- Eastern half exiled early (1 Chronicles 5)
- Western half blended into broader tribal identity

Teaching Contrast

- Ephraim = **Led strongly—but in the wrong direction**
- Manasseh = **Never fully stepped into full potential**

5. CORE SPIRITUAL LESSON

Ephraim teaches:

- Being chosen is not enough
- Proximity to God must be stewarded
- Influence without humility leads to

Manasseh teaches:

- Division weakens effectiveness

- Partial obedience leads to long-term struggle
- Strength must be focused to be effective

6. PRACTICAL + EMOTIONAL TAKEAWAY

Ephraim

- “I was given more than I expected... and I let it get to me.”
 □ The danger of **success without stewardship**

Manasseh

- “I had strength... but I was spread too thin.”
 □ The danger of **potential without focus**

7. POWERFUL PREACHING LINES

- “Ephraim had position but lost perspective.”
- “Manasseh had strength but lacked concentration.”
- “One was central but drifted—one was divided and diluted.”
- “Blessing tests you just as much as struggle does.”
- “It’s not just what God gives you—it’s how you carry it.”

8. FINAL SUMMARY

Category	Ephraim	Manasseh
Birth Order	Younger	Firstborn
Blessing	Greater	Secondary

Land	Central	Divided
Strength	Influence	Expansion
Weakness	Pride	Compromise
Outcome	Led but drifted	Present but less impactful

CLOSING LINE

“Ephraim shows what happens when you rise and forget God...
Manasseh shows what happens when you have strength but
never fully step into it.”

BENJAMIN (3 minutes)

Benjamin received a small but incredibly strategic territory between Judah and Ephraim. This land included Jerusalem (though not fully possessed at the time). Though small, it was powerful in positioning.

Benjamin’s story shows that **your impact is not determined by size, but by placement**. From this tribe came King Saul and later the Apostle Paul. Small territory, big influence.

SIMEON (2–3 minutes)

Simeon's inheritance was בתוך (within) Judah's territory. They did not have a distinct large region of their own but were scattered within Judah's land.

This fulfills Jacob's prophecy that Simeon would be divided and scattered. Yet even in that, God provided for them. Simeon teaches us that even when consequences follow past actions, **God still makes room for you within His plan.**

ZEBULUN (2–3 minutes)

Zebulun's land was located in the north, near major trade routes. Though not directly coastal, it benefited economically from its proximity to commerce.

Jacob prophesied that Zebulun would dwell by the sea and be a haven for ships. Their placement reflects access, influence, and connection. Zebulun shows us that **God positions some people in places of influence and interaction for kingdom impact.**

ISSACHAR (2–3 minutes)

Issachar received fertile land in the Jezreel Valley, one of the most productive agricultural regions. Their inheritance was rich and fruitful.

Jacob described Issachar as strong but склонный to comfort. Their land reflects abundance—but also the temptation to settle. Issachar teaches that **blessing requires discipline, or it can lead to complacency.**

ASHER (2–3 minutes)

Asher's land was along the northern coast, known for its rich soil and olive oil production. It was one of the most fertile and prosperous regions.

Jacob said Asher's food would be rich. That prophecy came to life in their land. Asher represents those who are blessed materially—but must remember to stay spiritually aligned.

NAPHTALI (2–3 minutes)

Naphtali's territory was in the north, around the Sea of Galilee. It was beautiful and free-flowing land.

Jacob described Naphtali as a deer let loose—symbolizing freedom and expression. Interestingly, this region later becomes central in Jesus' ministry. Naphtali shows us that **what seems distant now may become central later in God's plan.**

DAN (3 minutes)

Dan originally received land near the Philistines, but struggled to possess it. Instead of fully conquering, they migrated north and took a different territory.

This reflects Jacob's prophecy—Dan would judge, but also be like a serpent. Their story is one of compromise and redirection. Dan teaches that **when we avoid hard battles, we often settle for less than God intended.**

LEVITES (3 minutes)

The Levites received no territorial inheritance. Instead, they were given cities scattered throughout Israel.

Their inheritance was **the Lord Himself**. This is powerful—while others received land, they received presence. It reminds us that **intimacy with God is the highest inheritance**.

JOSHUA'S INHERITANCE (2 minutes)

Joshua received his portion last—Timnath-Serah. After leading everyone else into their inheritance, he finally received his own.

That's leadership. That's servanthood. Joshua shows us that **those who help others step into promise will not be forgotten by God**.

CLOSING (5 minutes)

This was not random land division.

This was:

- prophecy fulfilled
- identity revealed
- destiny assigned

And just like Israel:

You have an inheritance.

It may not be fully possessed yet.

It may still have giants in it.

It may require faith to walk into it.

But hear this clearly:

It has already been assigned.

If you want, I can also:

- Turn this into **sermon slides**
- Add **illustrations and stories for each tribe**
- Or create a **map visual + prophetic chart overlay**